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What Nobody Told Me: Unlocking Three Unwritten Rules for Thriving as a Clinician Scholar-Educator --Manuscript Draft--

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Abstract:	Every profession has a hidden curriculum: lessons that shape careers but are rarely written down. Clinician scholar-educators have one too, learned informally, through observation or fortunate mentorship, or not at all. Written from lived experience as a first-generation immigrant and introverts, this perspective shares three rules learned late or the hard way: your niche is your currency, not a limitation; sponsorship must be asked for, not waited on; and relational work is scholarly work, and must be narrated as such.

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To: Journal of Graduate Medical Education

Dear Dr. Gail M. Sullivan

We are pleased to submit our Perspective manuscript, **“What Nobody Told Me: Unlocking Three Unwritten Rules for Thriving as a Clinician Scholar-Educator,”** for consideration for publication in the Journal of Graduate Medical Education as a perspective piece.

Clinician scholar-educators build careers through teaching, mentorship, educational scholarship, and program development, yet the unwritten rules that surround promotion along this academic path are rarely taught explicitly. In this Perspective, we draw on our own experiences, including navigating academic medicine as a first-generation immigrant and as introverts, to share three lessons we wish someone had told us sooner. Each lesson closes with concrete guidance for both mentors and mentees.

We believe this manuscript will resonate with JGME’s readership of educators, mentors, program directors, core faculty and trainees who are working to make the hidden curriculum of academic medicine more explicit and more equitable, particularly for faculty from backgrounds that are underrepresented in academic medicine. The themes align closely with JGME’s ongoing interest in mentorship, sponsorship, and career development in graduate medical education.

This manuscript is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration by any other journal. Both authors have read and approved the final version and meet the criteria for authorship. This work received no financial support. The word count for this perspective piece is 1,196 words.

Thank you for your time and consideration. We look forward to your response and would be happy to provide any additional information that may be helpful.

Sincerely,

Radhika

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On behalf of co-author Adelaide H. McClintock, MD

What Nobody Told Me: Unlocking Three Unwritten Rules for Thriving as a Clinician Scholar-Educator

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Introduction

Clinician scholar-educators follow a career path distinct from the traditional physician-scientist model. Careers are built through teaching, mentorship, educational scholarship, and program development. Yet the impact of this work can be harder to measure than grants or manuscripts, and the rules of success are rarely explicitly taught(1).

We came to this work from different backgrounds but with a shared experience of learning those rules late. One of us is the daughter of first-generation South Asian immigrants, raised to believe that hard work, humility, and service would speak for themselves. Both of us found self-advocacy and asking for opportunities far less intuitive than simply doing the work. Those values served us well, but they left us unprepared for an academic culture that rewards visibility, sponsorship, and the ability to articulate impact.

Having progressed from mentees to mentors, this perspective offers three lessons we wish someone had told us, each addressed to mentors, who can make the hidden curriculum explicit, and to mentees, who deserve to hear these lessons now rather than spend a decade discovering it themselves.

Rule 1: Your Niche Is Your Currency, Not Your Limitation

Find the thing you would teach for free. Then teach it everywhere.

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4 Early in our careers, we thought success would be found in keeping our interests broad.
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6 We eventually learned that clinician scholar-educators build influence through depth. A
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8 niche is the intersection of expertise, an educational problem worth solving, and
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10 sustained contribution. Over time, repetition becomes reputation, giving colleagues
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12 clarity about what they seek your expertise for.
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17 One of us found that niche in osteoporosis, not because it was glamorous or the sexiest
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19 disease, but because it mattered to us. Over more than a decade, that commitment
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21 grew into multidisciplinary clinical programs, educational innovation, quality
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23 improvement, and national teaching. We did not plan to become "the osteoporosis
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25 educator." We kept returning to the same problem until colleagues began associating us
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27 with it.
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37 Being one of the few clinician educators at the intersection of a specialty and medical
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39 education can feel isolating. Often, however, that isolation is the beginning of a niche.
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41 Keep investing in the work that continues to energize you. Depth builds credibility, and
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43 credibility creates opportunity.
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47 A second part of this rule: reusing your work is not laziness. It is how knowledge scales.
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49 The CME lecture you first gave in 2021, updated annually for new audiences, is not the
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51 same lecture—it is an evolving body of educational scholarship. Physician-scientists
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53 advance knowledge through discovery; clinician educators advance it through
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55 refinement, dissemination, and implementation. See Figure 1.
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To Mentors: Help your mentees identify the educational problem that energizes them and that they keep returning to. Protect time for them to develop it and sponsor them to teach before they have an extensive track record. One invitation can launch a reputation.

To Mentees: You do not need a new idea every year. You need one idea you pursue with more depth and in more places than feels comfortable. Update last year's lecture and make it ten percent better. Turn it into a workshop, a chalk talk, or book chapter. Repetition is not lack of creativity; it is how expertise becomes recognizable. If repetition feels boring, adapt and iterate.

Rule 2

Waiting to be noticed is a strategy. It just isn't a very effective one.

We believed hard work would speak for itself. For many first-generation, immigrant, or underrepresented faculty, that belief carries us far, but not far enough.

Many academic opportunities—committee appointments, invited talks, collaborations, and leadership roles—arise through sponsorship. Mentors offer guidance; sponsors use their credibility to create opportunities (2,3,4).

Like many introverts, asking felt unnatural. One email sat in the draft folder for days. It was rewritten four times because it felt presumptuous. Looking back, the request itself was never the problem. Sponsors cannot advocate for goals they do not know you have.

For introverts, and for those from cultures where directness feels transgressive, this bears repeating: asking takes energy, and that cost is real, not imagined. Draft the email slowly. Practice the conversation. Ask for feedback. What you cannot do is skip the ask.

Specific asks help sponsors help you. Some people will not respond. Others will forget. Follow up. If one sponsor says no, find another. See figure 2.

To Mentors: Ask your mentees what opportunity they hope comes next. Then make one introduction, one recommendation, or one nomination.

To Mentees: Write the email. Make the ask. The discomfort is not evidence that you should stay silent, it is evidence that you are learning a skill that no one explicitly taught you.

Rule 3

A CV doesn't narrate your impact, it will always undersell you.

Academic promotion systems were largely designed around the physician-scientist model, where grants, publications, and citations are readily measured. Clinician scholar-educators create impact differently, and too often we are never taught how to describe that work.

Helping a resident rewrite a personal statement will never appear in a citation database. Yet that resident may mentor dozens more. Likewise, a CME lecture may change how forty physicians order bone density scans, with effects that ripple through generations of learners. A culture you build where trainees feel safe asking for help can transform the learning experience and ensure safe patient care. This work is real. It is scholarly. It may have more lasting impact than a paper that is read, cited, and then never changes practice. The challenge is not the value of this work but our failure to describe it in the language of academic promotion. Narrating impact means translating educational work

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4 into evidence: Who was reached? What changed? How did it spread? Why did it
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6 matter? (5, 6)
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10 Recognize achievements for what they are. Being appointed to a national committee is
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12 not simply another line on your CV—it is evidence that your peers recognized your
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14 expertise. Say so.
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18 During promotion, a mentor helped one of us translate years of educational work into
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20 language promotion committees could understand. Until that moment, it had never
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22 occurred to us that this was something that could be done, and certainly not something
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24 that we could ask for help doing.
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29 **To Mentors:** Read teaching portfolios with the same attention you give publication lists.
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31 Teach mentees how to translate educational work into evidence of impact.
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35 **To Mentees:** Do not minimize your contributions. Replace "gave several lectures" with
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37 language that explains who was reached, what changed, and why it mattered. If you do
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39 not tell the story of your impact, no one else will know it's there.
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43 Conclusion:
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47 These three rules are not a complete roadmap. These are simply the lessons we wish
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49 someone had shared earlier. The hidden curriculum of clinician scholar-educators
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51 should not depend on luck, proximity to influential mentors, or years of trial and error.
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54 Making these lessons explicit is one of our greatest opportunities to strengthen the next
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56 generation.
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To the mentors who say the quiet parts out loud, thank you. You shorten learning curves, open doors, and help others see possibilities they might never have imagined for themselves. To those still finding their way, your voice will grow stronger. Your impact is already larger than you realize. We're clapping for you.

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FIGURES

Figure 1: Rule #1- **The Niche Rubric**

Four checkpoints for building a teaching identity that holds up over time



Figure 2: *Sponsorship Doesn't Find You — You Have to Ask For It*

For the First-Generation Immigrant or Introvert Clinician Scholars/Educators

